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PROUD OF HERSELF: Tweet's latest single, *Call Me*, is at No. 9 on the national r&b and hip-hop chart.

Tweet's lyrics set off an uproar

BY VANESSA E. JONES
THE BOSTON GLOBE

Urban contemporary singer Tweet's hit *Oops (Oh My)* peaked at No. 7 on *Billboard* magazine's pop chart in May, thanks to its techno-reggae rhythm, but the song's lyrical content made some listeners blush.

Oops, there goes my shirt up over my head, oh my/Oops, there goes my skirt droppin' to my feet, oh my/Ooh, some kind of touch caressing my legs, oh my/ Ooh, I'm turning red, who could this be?

The perpetrator, fans discover, is a young woman practicing an age-old way of getting in touch with herself. In this jaded age where the word vagina is used in a play's title and hit songs detail explicit sex, female masturbation is one subject some people still consider taboo.

In Los Angeles, Adimu, the afternoon DJ on KKBT-FM "The Beat," has introduced the Timbaland-produced *Oops (Oh My)* as the "nasty, nasty, nasty song." In Boston, T. Clark, the evening DJ for the urban station WBOT-FM "Hot 97," recently asked listeners to voice opinions about *Oops (Oh My)*. One woman's on-air reply: "I have a 7-year-old child going around the house singing that song before she even had a chance to decipher exactly what she was talking about. That song is hot and stuff, but I think it needs to be a little bit cleaned up."

Oops (Oh My) was so hot that Nicole Cardwell and her husband forbade their 12-year-old daughter, Shanay, from singing it. "I thought it was disgusting," says Cardwell, 32, who lives in Dorchester, Mass. "I just don't think kids should be told how to do those things."

Others, however, sound almost blase about the ode to a young woman who, as the lyrics detail, *came home, say, around a quarter to 3/still so high, hypnotized, in a trance/from this body, so buttery brown and tantalizing.* So what if she decided to douse her own fire?

"We're all so desensitized at this point," says Shani Saxon, music editor at *Vibe* magazine. "I'm surprised anyone thinks that a song about masturbation would be a big deal. I would expect the majority of people to be like, 'Whatever.' "

That's been the reaction of some listeners to Tweet's debut, which hit No. 1 on *Billboard*'s r&b singles chart. The 30-year-old protege of rapper and producer Missy Elliott released her first CD, *Southern Hummingbird*, on April 2. She is the opening act for Mary J. Blige Wednesday at Miami's AmericanAirlines Arena.

"We've been playing it for a while," Clark says. "Not one call."

When asked about it, members of the Boston Blacks Online Web community were similarly nonchalant: "She's exploring herself," writes Lisa Bynoe, 24, a Dorchester resident. "There's nothing degrading about that."

This country has come a long way since M. Joycelyn Elders got booted from the surgeon general job in 1994 for suggesting that self-gratification be discussed in school sex-education classes. At that time, Elders says, "We never talked about it. You couldn't even say the word."

The floodgates opened around the time of the Elders uproar. Now people discuss the "M" word and buy how-to guides such as *The Joy of Self-Pleasuring: Why Feel Guilty About Feeling Good?*

"There are teachers saying,

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